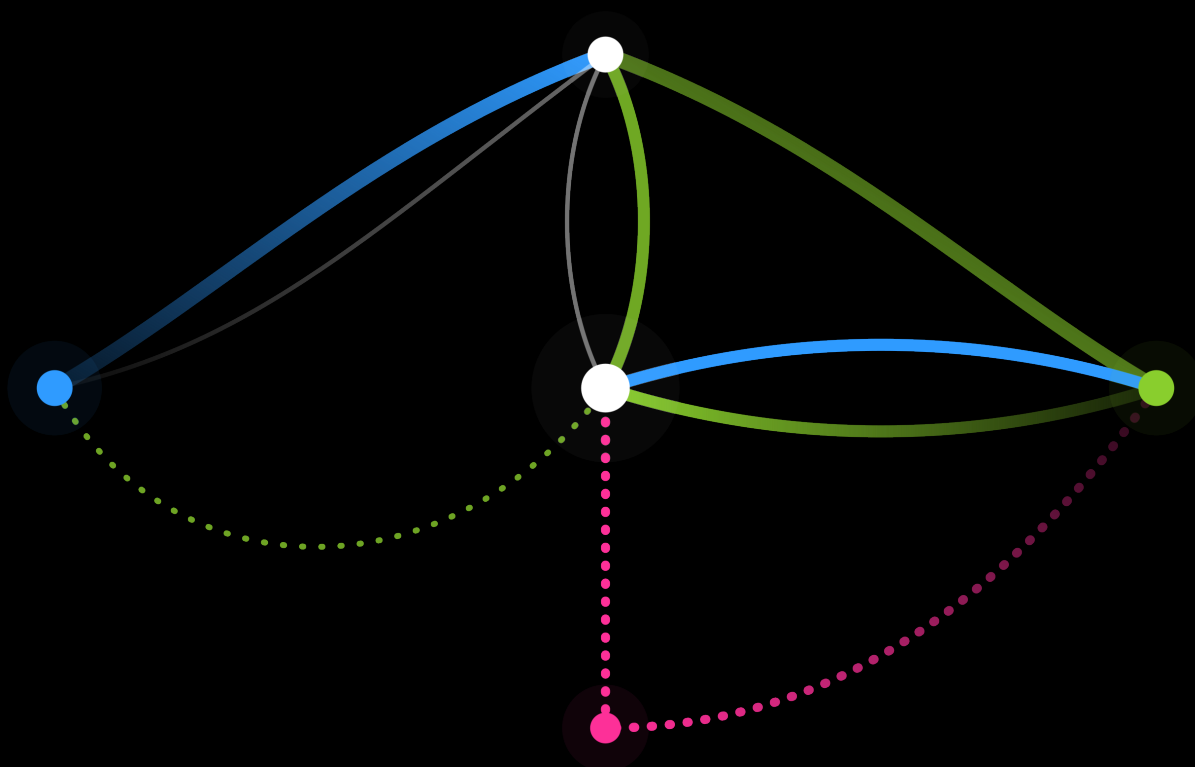




Indica

THE INFLUENCER ECONOMY

Introduction to the series: **the economic design** of the influence market



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Founded in 2024, INDICA is a communications and influencer-marketing agency. Through the influence market we defend science, democracy and the environment, connecting creators, data and narrative to move public opinion around what matters.

Beyond campaigns and productions, INDICA produces knowledge. This text opens the agency's series *The influencer economy*, on how the digital influence market works, written from data and from the practice of those who operate in it. It is the entry point to the series: it describes the market from which every study starts. Each study has its own authors and refers back to this introduction.

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ABSTRACT

What this introduction presents

This introduction opens the series The influencer economy and describes, in its simplest design, how the influence market works: who its participants are, what each one gives and receives, and where attention and money flow. From that design it points out three things it reveals: the creator is the source of value in the system and the party with the least control over its own income; the brand appears twice, buying generic attention from the platform and attention with credibility from the creator; and the public, which pays almost nothing, is the origin of everything. It discusses why this market deserves to be studied with the tools of economic theory and what is at stake when it organizes the production of information around whoever can pay for attention. Finally, it presents the fields the series covers: the demand for attention, the formation of price and the intermediaries.

KEYWORDS

influencer economy

attention market

platforms

intermediation

credibility

public interest

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SECTION 1

Why study this market

There is an economic activity that takes up hours of the day of billions of people, moves advertising budgets the size of entire industrial sectors, defines what much of the population knows about politics, health, science and the environment, and about which there is almost no theory. It is the influence market: the set of economic relations that form around people who publish content on social networks and build an audience by doing so.

A great deal is said about influencers. What they say, what they sell, what they get wrong, what they earn. Very little is said about how this market works: what is bought and what is sold, who ends up with what, why prices are what they are, why some voices grow and others do not, and what all of this does to the information that circulates. The questions economics asks of any market, about supply, demand, price, competition and the distribution of income, have rarely been asked of this one.

This series exists to ask them. It brings together a set of studies, published in parts, that examine the influence market with the tools of economic theory. Some are theoretical: they propose models that explain what is observed. Others are empirical: they go into the field to listen to those who make a living in this market and describe what they find. All of them start from the same description of the market, which is the subject of this introduction, and all of them try to answer, each in its own way, a question that seems central to us: how a market organized to sell attention can be understood, and eventually redirected, in the service of the public interest.

We write from a specific place. INDICA operates in this market: it works with content creators, builds campaigns, negotiates prices, measures results. And at the same time it studies the market, with method and with the intention of publishing what it learns. Operating and studying at the same time has a cost, which is the suspicion of partiality, and an advantage, which is access. We know how the market works from the inside because we are inside it. What this series offers is the attempt to turn that access into knowledge that can be verified, criticized and used by those on the outside.

SECTION 2

How the market works

Let us begin with the simplest possible design. The influence market has four participants: the public, the platform, the creator and the brand. Each comes in with something and leaves with something, and what circulates between them is attention and money.

Creators publish for free on platforms. This is the starting point, and it is worth dwelling on, because it is what makes this market different from almost every other. The creator produces content and hands it to the platform without charging anything for it. The platform distributes it to the public, also without charging. The public consumes the content and, in consuming it, gives the platform the only thing it has to offer: attention. There is no monetary transaction in any of these three steps. The content is free, the distribution is free, the consumption is free. What circulates is attention. And it is not one creator: there are many, thousands, publishing at the same time on the same subjects and competing for the same attention, which is finite. The supply of content has no limit, because publishing is free; the demand for it, measured in attention, has the limit of each person's time.

The platform earns its revenue by selling advertising to companies. The attention the public gives when it consumes creators' content accumulates on the platform. It is this accumulation that the platform sells. Companies pay the platform for space in front of that attention, that is, they pay for the attention the creators attracted by publishing for free, and the platform displays the advertising to the public, mixed in with the creators' content. That is what closes the cycle: the attention the public gives comes back to it in the form of advertising. The platform's business is to convert into advertising revenue the attention that others produced. It does not produce the content that attracts the public; it organizes distribution, measures the result and sells access.

Creators earn income in three ways. The first is by selling, directly to companies, the credibility and the attention of their own profile. The companies that buy this want one of two things, or both at once: greater reach, that is, to get to the public that follows that creator; and to attach themselves to the creator's image, that is, to transfer to the brand part of the trust the public places in them. The second is through the platform's own monetization systems, which pass on to the creator a share of the revenue the platform obtained from the attention accumulated on their content. In that case, the creator receives a fraction of what the platform sold to companies, and the fraction is set by the platform. The third is direct payment from the public: subscriptions, membership programs, courses, products of their own, donations during live streams. For most creators it is the smallest of the three, and it is the only one with no intermediary: the creator captures the entire income from their own asset.

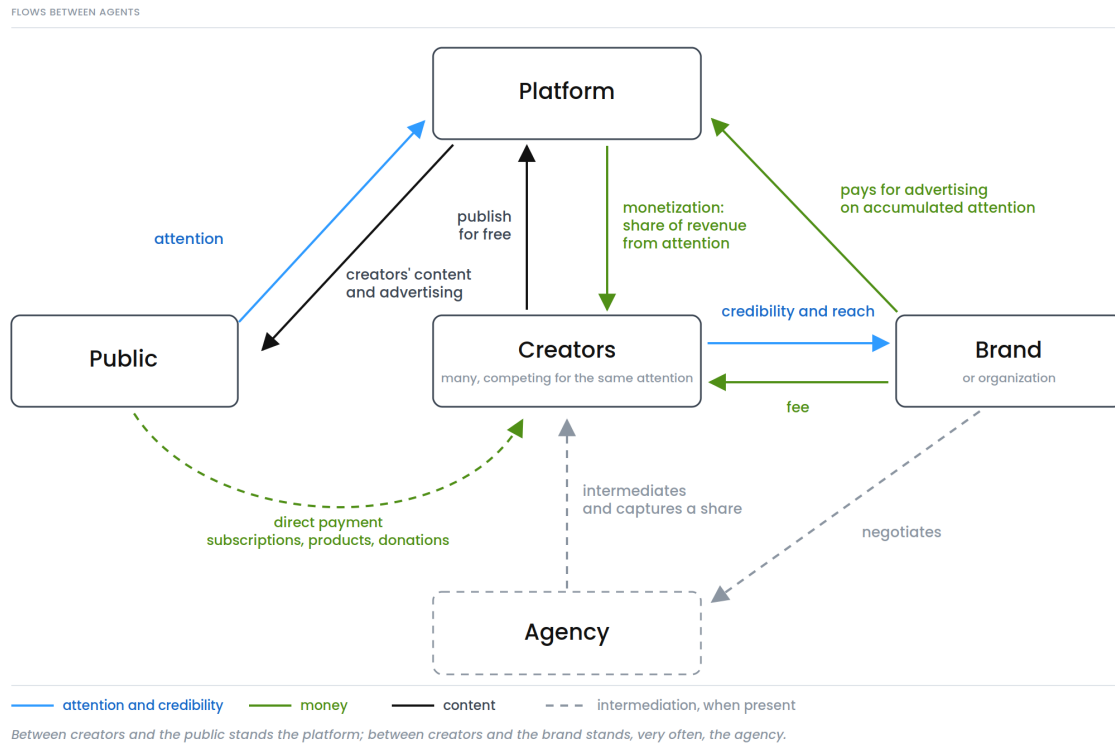
The public-interest organization currently enters in the brand's place. When a civil-society organization, a public institution or a news outlet hires a creator, it occupies exactly the brand's position in the design: it pays a fee, it receives credibility and reach. The design puts it there because that is how the market works. Whether that is the right place for it is the question that runs through the series.

There are two intermediaries. Between the creator and the public stands the platform, which decides what is distributed to whom and captures the resulting attention. Between the creator and the brand stands, very often, the agency, which negotiates on the creator's behalf and captures part of the value of the transac-

tion. The creator has no direct access to the public, because access goes through the platform. And frequently has no direct access to the brand, because access goes through the agency.

FIGURE 1

The economic design of the influence market



Note. Authors' own elaboration (2026).

This is the economic design of the ecosystem. It fits in one figure and one page, and it is deliberately simple. But it contains, in embryo, every question the series develops. Three things in it are worth pointing out before moving on.

SECTION 3

Three observations about the design

3.1 The creator is the source of value and the party with the least control over its own income

It is the creator's content that attracts the public's attention. It is that attention the platform sells to companies. It is the creator's credibility the brand buys when it hires them. In every transaction in the system, what is sold was produced by the creator.

And yet the creator is the party that decides the least about what it receives. The platform sets how much of the advertising revenue it passes on, and can change that proportion whenever it wishes. The platform also sets how much of the creator's content will be distributed, and therefore how much attention it accumulates, through a recommendation system whose rules are not public. The agency, when there is one, sets how much of the negotiated fee reaches the creator. The creator, who stands at the center of the design, has less power over its own result than any other participant.

This is not an anomaly; it is the structure. And it is the first thing the series examines: why a market in which the source of value is so clear distributes that value so unequally.

3.2 The brand appears twice, in two different positions

The company that wants attention has two routes. It can pay the platform for advertising: it buys space in front of the accumulated attention, with no creator involved. Or it can pay the creator for a piece of content: it buys the specific attention of that creator's public, together with the trust that public places in them.

These are distinct transactions, with distinct logics. In advertising, the brand buys generic attention, measured in impressions, and pays per unit. In the fee, it buys specific attention together with credibility, and pays per piece. The second is far more expensive per unit of attention. A video by a creator with one hundred thousand followers costs more, per person reached, than an advertisement that reaches the same one hundred thousand people.

Why does a company pay more for the same reach? Because it is not buying the same product. It is buying something advertising does not have: the voice of someone the public trusts. The price difference between the two transactions is the measure of the value of credibility, and it is one of the things the series sets out to explain.

3.3 The public pays almost nothing and is the origin of everything

The public gives attention in exchange for content. Apart from direct payment to some creators, which is the exception and not the rule, it pays nothing in money, either to the creator or to the platform. But the attention it gives is what every other participant competes for: the platform sells it, the creator monetizes it, the brand buys it. Everything that circulates as money in this market originates in a finite quantity of attention that the public distributes among the content available.

That makes attention the scarce resource of the system. Each person has a limited number of hours per day, and each piece of content published competes with every other for a fraction of that time. The supply of content grows without limit, because publishing is free; the demand for content, measured in attention, is limited by the time available. A market in which supply is unlimited and demand is finite has particular properties, and it is on them that the economic model that opens the series is built.

SECTION 4

What is at stake

We could study this market out of intellectual curiosity alone, and it would be justified: it is a new, large and poorly understood market. But there is a stronger reason, and it is the one that moves us.

The influence market is today one of the main sources of information for a large part of the population. For many people, what they know about a vaccine, an election, a public policy or a change in the climate arrived through a content creator, and not through a newspaper, a school or an institution. That is not a value judgment; it is a description. And it has a consequence: the way this market organizes the production and distribution of content determines, to a large extent, what circulates and what does not circulate as information.

The design we described above organizes the market around whoever can pay for attention. The platform sells attention to whoever pays for advertising. The creator sells credibility to whoever pays a fee. Subjects that have a buyer with a budget find, in this market, someone to take them to the public. Subjects that have no buyer are left out, or enter residually, as an exception or as a favor.

Public-interest subjects are, for the most part, in the second group. There is no brand that pays for people to talk about public health, electoral integrity, science or conservation, or there is far less of it than pays for people to talk about products. The result is that content on these subjects depends on the goodwill of creators who agree to produce it without pay, and goodwill is a resource that runs out. The creator who devotes weeks to a subject that does not pay is subtracting those weeks from subjects that do, and cannot do that indefinitely.

Worse: the space that public-interest subjects do not occupy does not stay empty. It is occupied by those with a direct interest in the framing and the means to pay for it. Economic sectors with much to lose in certain debates hire creators to attach their brand to the agendas that interest them, and do so with brand-sized budgets. The silence of the public interest in this market is not neutrality; it is ceding ground.

Understanding the market is the condition for changing that. One does not redirect a system one does not understand. The series is the attempt to understand it with enough rigor for redirection to be possible.

SECTION 5

What the series covers

The studies that make up the series start from the description above and develop it in three directions. The first is demand: what attention is as a scarce resource, how interest in a subject forms, why content already published continues to compete with new content, and how a subject saturates. The second is price: what is actually sold when a creator is hired, why that price detaches from the cost of production, how it decomposes and how it is negotiated. The third is the intermediaries: what the platform does with the creator's access to the public, what the agency does with the creator's access to the brand, and what the two positions do to the content that circulates. Some studies are theoretical and propose models; others are empirical and go into the field to listen to those who make a living in this market. Each has its own authors and reads on its own, and all of them refer back to this introduction as a common starting point.

We do not claim to have said the last word on anything. This is a new field, and the studies gathered here are, for the most part, first attempts. They will be corrected, contested and superseded, and that is as it should be. What we hope is that they serve as a basis for others to do better, and that they help those who work with content creators, in civil-society organizations, in public institutions, in news outlets or on the networks themselves, to understand the market they operate in.

There is one last thing worth saying. We study this market because we believe it can be redirected. The attention that today is sold to whoever can pay can, in part, be put in the service of science, of the integrity of public debate and of the environment. Not by decree, nor against the market, but from within it, with creators who have an economic reason to address subjects that matter and with organizations that know how to work with them. Understanding the market is the first step. This series is that step.

About the author



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ABOUT INDICA

INDICA is a communications and influencer-marketing agency founded in 2024. It works on mobilization campaigns, audiovisual production and strategic network management, with a network of more than 200 communicators, around three axes: democracy, science and the environment. The agency's publications gather the knowledge produced in that practice.



Communication with purpose.
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